CERNO GLOBUS

FIELD INTELLIGENCE

Issue 006 Wednesday, October 28, 2026 · Biweekly, 4 pages

Practices

Dental · Veterinary · Aesthetics · Chiropractic & Physical Therapy · Optometry & Vision · Behavioral & Mental Health

Six trades, one publication. Every item is something that moves a number on your P&L, changes what you must do by law, or changes what parts and labor cost you.

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Read it online
This issue, and every one before it

SUPPLY

Wedgewood Pharmacy recalled nearly 4,000 compounded veterinary product listings on October 21 over potency doubts, covering shipments from February 18 to October 6 that reached practices nationwide.

Wedgewood Pharmacy LLC of Swedesboro, New Jersey announced a voluntary recall on October 21 covering nearly 4,000 compounded veterinary product listings shipped nationwide from February 18 to October 6, 2026. The company says unreliable laboratory testing data means products may be subpotent or superpotent. Every affected product is still within its expiration date. Wedgewood says the recall is being conducted with FDA's knowledge.

The listings span powders, pastes, oral suspensions, injectables, ophthalmic ointments and solutions, ear products, and topical sprays and gels, for companion, equine, exotic, zoo, wildlife and aquatic animals. They are not for food-producing animals. Subpotent product may be ineffective and superpotent product may cause toxicity or overdose. Wedgewood has received 98 complaints, 7 of them serious, and has not described them.

Wedgewood tells practices to do four things: check inventory for affected lots, quarantine affected product, contact recall services, and identify and notify the clients who received it. A recall lookup on its site finds lot numbers and expiration dates by product name or SKU. Sedgwick is coordinating notices and arranging refunds or replacements where possible. Recall services is 866-562-5931, Monday to Friday 8am to 9pm ET and Saturday 9am to 5pm ET.

Owners are told to stop using the affected product, keep it, and call their veterinarian and the recall line. Wedgewood says it is working with clinicians to find clinically appropriate alternatives. Adverse reactions go to FDA at 1-888-FDA-VETS.

What to do about it: Today, pull every Wedgewood product on your shelves and in your dispensing log from February 18 onward and run each SKU through the company's recall lookup before another refill goes out. Quarantine matches, record lot, quantity and date, and call 866-562-5931 to start the refund or replacement claim. Export dispensing records for the same period and list every client who received a product; call the owners of injectable and ophthalmic prescriptions first, then send a written notice to the rest and log each contact in the chart. Ask your lead veterinarian to decide patient by patient who needs a recheck or a substitute from another pharmacy. Tell your professional liability carrier in writing what you received and what you did. Tell clients to keep the product, as Wedgewood instructs.

dvm360: Wedgewood recalls nearly 4,000 products · dvm360: Weekly Vet Report, October 23

DENTAL

TWO ITEMS

LABOR

CMS announced $16.4 million on October 19 for Maryland rural healthcare workforce training, including dental assistant tuition, transportation and uniforms and help recruiting and retaining rural dentists.

Why it matters: The money is part of Maryland's Rural Health Transformation Program award under the Working Families Tax Cuts Act, which CMS calls a $50 billion state investment. It pays for apprenticeships, training and certification costs, and recruiting and retaining nurses, physicians, dentists and other clinicians in rural communities. If you hire assistants in rural Maryland, ask your county health department this week which agency is placing the dental assistant funds and whether your office can host an apprentice.

CMS: $16M for Maryland rural workforce, Oct 19 · CMS MLN Connects Newsletter, October 22, 2026

MONEY

ADA News reported October 16 that HHS gave $51 million to 28 health centers, up to $2 million each, to expand dental care for children with neurodevelopmental disorders including autism and Down syndrome.

Why it matters: The awards run through HRSA's Quality Improvement Fund to HRSA-funded health centers, not private practices; ADA News names La Clinica in California and Salud Family Health in Colorado. The money pays for preventive and other dental services, and workforce training, and all 28 recipients join a shared evaluation. A health center near you may be hiring dentists or looking for specialists to refer to. Find out whether a health center in your county is an awardee, and call its dental director if you treat these patients.

ADA News: HHS awards $51M for children's dental care

VETERINARY

TWO ITEMS

DEMAND

Cat clinical visits rose 2.7% in the third quarter from a year earlier while puppy visits fell 10% in July to September and all-species visits fell 1.9%, CATalyst Council reported October 13.

Why it matters: The Council's Feline Veterinary Market Insights, built on Vetsource data from 6,595 practices, puts cats at 24% of companion animal visits, up from 21% about three years ago, with growth in each of the last 12 quarters. Kitten visits slipped 0.9% in July to September but run about 11% above the 2018-2019 baseline; puppies are about 44% below it. It projects combined dog and cat visits falling 1% to 2% a year for a decade. This week, pull your third-quarter visits by species against last year; if cats are under a quarter of your visits, check your cat-friendly scheduling, handling and booking language.

dvm360: Kitten visits hold steady as puppies slow

LABOR

A Penn Foster and Harris Poll survey released October 22 finds 65% of pet owners have booked or would book a technician directly, and 55% of technicians say their skills are underused.

Why it matters: The June 2026 surveys covered 509 pet owners and 206 technicians (technicians surveyed June 8-15). 80% say they are qualified to run vaccine visits independently, 78% routine wellness exams and 69% client education and care plans; 76% say current staffing structures limit appointments. They name clinic culture (44%), policies (42%) and veterinarian trust (38%) as barriers. Penn Foster is a training company, so treat this as direction rather than proof. Check what your state's practice act lets technicians do without a veterinarian present, then test one technician-led vaccine hour and track revenue for it.

dvm360: Untapped clinical resource may be on staff

AESTHETICS

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

HHS and FDA sent an interim access policy for compounding certain peptides, reportedly including BPC-157, to White House review, American Med Spa Association reported October 16; the terms are unpublished.

Why it matters: The policy would use enforcement discretion, so FDA would hold off acting against pharmacies compounding listed peptides while it writes permanent rules. It is not approval and is separate from adding peptides to the 503A bulks list, which needs rulemaking that could take years. In July the compounding advisory committee recommended six of seven peptides for that list, including BPC-157 and TB-500, though FDA staff said safety and effectiveness data are thin. The peptides remain unapproved drugs and state rules on prescribing and supervision still apply. Do not add peptides to your menu or marketing on this news; ask your pharmacy in writing about its state licensure.

AmSpa: FDA peptide policy sent to White House

SUPPLY

FDA classified Apothecary Pharma's recall of 22 vials of compounded tirzepatide and one NAD+ vial as Class II on October 8, with sterility not assured, American Med Spa Association reported October 22.

Why it matters: The North Carolina compounder began the voluntary recall on September 24; FDA's notice reports no illnesses or injuries. Affected: tirzepatide 18 mg/mL, 4 mL multidose vials (NDC 85091-001-18), lots AP-202622 to AP-202644 except AP-202626, and one NAD+ 200 mg/mL, 6 mL vial (NDC 85091-011-06), lot AP-202647. FDA sent the firm a warning letter in December 2025 over sterile production. Check stock by NDC and lot, isolate matches, and use dispensing records to find any patient who received them; your medical director sets the outreach.

AmSpa: Compounded tirzepatide, NAD+ recalled

CHIROPRACTIC & PHYSICAL THERAPY

TWO ITEMS

MONEY

CMS's October 22 provider newsletter tells Medicare billers to confirm Medicaid and QMB status before billing cost sharing, because dual-eligible patients who lose Medicaid also lose QMB protections.

Why it matters: Starting October 1, federal law generally limits Medicaid funding for lawful permanent residents, Cuban and Haitian entrants and Compact of Free Association migrants, with some exceptions. CMS says a dual-eligible patient who loses Medicaid no longer has the cost-sharing protections required for QMBs. For physical therapy and chiropractic offices that changes who you may bill for cost sharing. Check status through HETS before billing or collecting. Add a Medicaid and QMB check to front-desk verification and rerun it on your Medicare patients this month.

CMS MLN Connects Newsletter, October 22, 2026

INSURANCE

APTA posted updated value-based care resources for members on October 21, and its September 25 review found none of the codes commonly used in physical therapy among UnitedHealthcare's 30% prior authorization cuts announced September 1.

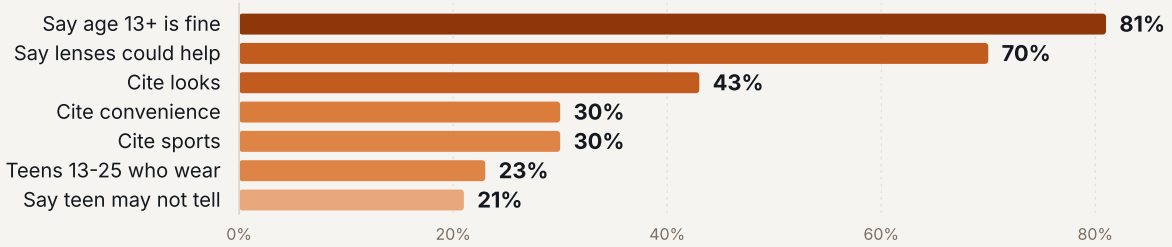
Why it matters: UnitedHealthcare announced on September 1 that it is eliminating 30% of prior authorization requirements. APTA found no commonly used physical therapy code on the list and is pressing UHC to clarify how the policy applies to PT. APTA's October 21 page, behind a member login or free account, offers resources on payment models and value-based care. Pull your ten highest-volume CPT codes and check each against UHC's current prior authorization list this week.

APTA: Value-based care resources, October 21 · APTA: Presses for PT codes in UHC prior auth cuts

INFOGRAPHIC 1 / TEEN LENS GAP

Seven in ten parents say contact lenses could benefit their child, but 23% of 13- to 25-year-olds who need correction wear them.

Share of respondents, percent. Alcon-sponsored Wakefield survey of 1,000 parents, fielded April 1-8, 2026; reported by Eyecare Business October 7, 2026. The 23% is the share of 13- to 25-year-olds needing correction who wear lenses.



Seven in ten parents see a benefit and 81% say 13 is old enough, yet 23% of 13- to 25-year-olds who need correction wear lenses. Alcon sells lenses and sponsored the survey, so read it as direction. Add a teen fitting offer to recall notices for ages 12 to 17, and ask teens directly at exams: 21% of parents say their teen probably would not tell them about trouble seeing. Eyecare Business: Parents' interest vs teen lens wear

OPTOMETRY & VISION

TWO ITEMS

SUPPLY

FDA warned that counterfeit Ocusan and related eye drops sold mainly in stores serving Spanish-speaking customers in Florida and Georgia include samples contaminated with bacteria, Eyecare Business reported October 19.

Why it matters: DLC Laboratory tested two counterfeits: Colirio Ocusan redness relief carried Staphylococcus and Ocusan Dry Eyes a bacterial type not yet confirmed. Contamination may cause serious eye infections. The products may also be in Louisiana, Mississippi and North Carolina; FDA knows of no adverse events, says testing continues and is working with distributors to remove the product. A separate retail recall covers one lot of Colirio Manzanilla A+, AR25N01, from September 11. Ask every patient with redness, discharge or an eye infection which drops they have used, document brand and store, and report cases to MedWatch at 800-FDA-1088.

Eyecare Business: FDA warns of counterfeit eye drops · PharmaNow: Counterfeit eye drops, DLC Laboratories

REGULATION

On October 14 the FTC proposed extending the Contact Lens Rule's information collection three years unchanged, and on October 15 a federal court certified a class action against Hubble Contacts.

Why it matters: The FTC notice proposes no substantive change, so your release and verification duties stay as they are. In Africa v. Vision Path Inc. in the Central District of California, the class covers California residents who bought Hubble Classic Daily subscriptions from April 25, 2019 without a prescription for those lenses; court records identify more than 95,543 California purchasers, not all in the class. Plaintiffs allege lens substitution and improper verification, Hubble disputes the claims, and certification does not decide liability. Hubble paid $3.5 million to settle FTC charges in 2022. Keep a dated log of every verification request you receive and how you answered it.

Eyecare Business: Hubble class action moves forward

BEHAVIORAL & MENTAL HEALTH

TWO ITEMS

REGULATION

DOJ charged a father and son who run 20-plus Southern California addiction treatment facilities with $1.62 billion in false claims to commercial insurers from May 2020 to May 2026, Behavioral Health Business reported October 23.

Why it matters: Officials call it the largest substance abuse treatment fraud in U.S. prosecution history, with more than $210 million paid. Charges include healthcare fraud and six counts under the Eliminating Kickbacks in Recovery Act (EKRA). Prosecutors allege body brokers recruited unhoused patients and billed outings as group therapy. The defendants have not pleaded and the allegations are unproven. In June DOJ charged 39 behavioral health billing fraud cases; addiction treatment providers were 68.7% of the suspected fraud. Have counsel review any payment to marketers or referral sources against EKRA, and match every billed group session to an attendance sheet and clinician note.

Behavioral Health Business: DOJ charges $1.6B SUD fraud

INSURANCE

Behavioral Health Business reported October 19 that CMS's 173-page Medicaid ABA toolkit, released in August, says higher-intensity services should not be authorized by default, making stock high-hour plans a potential fraud signal.

Why it matters: The toolkit, released in August, is not binding; each state decides how to apply it. It cites Medicaid and CHIP ABA spending rising from about $1.94 billion in 2021 to $10.1 billion in 2025, a 421% increase. Expect closer review of BCBA decisions when plans are written and reassessed,. One executive says some payers already flag plans above 30 or 35 hours. Audit your active plans for identical hours across clients and confirm each has dated, individual goals; ask your state Medicaid agency when it will adopt the toolkit.

Behavioral Health Business: ABA roadmap, October 19 · Behavioral Health Business: CMS ABA guidance, Aug 5

INFOGRAPHIC 2 / PATIENTS PER VET

Companion-predominant practices saw 16 patients per veterinarian per day in 2025 against 18 in 2022, and equine practices 8 against 10.

Patients per full-time-equivalent veterinarian per day, 2025 (low end) to 2022 (high end). AVMA 2026 Veterinary Practice Owners Survey, 775 practices; presented October 7-8 and reported by AVMA News October 8, 2026.

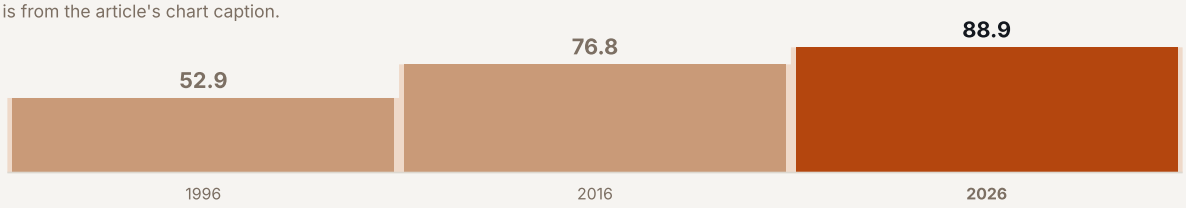


Two practice types lost volume per veterinarian: companion-predominant practices fell from 18 to 16 and equine from 10 to 8, while mixed and companion-exclusive practices held at about 15. AVMA links the drop to the national decline in veterinary visits, which it attributes in part to a slowing economy. Compare your own patients per veterinarian before adding exam rooms or hiring. AVMA News: Veterinary practice health, mixed report card

INFOGRAPHIC 3 / PET DOGS

The U.S. pet dog population has grown from 52.9 million in 1996 to 88.9 million in 2026, while household pet spending fell 14% this year.

Millions of pet dogs. AVMA 2026 Pet Ownership and Demographics Sourcebook, reported by AVMA News October 7, 2026; the 1996 figure is from the article's chart caption.



Dogs grew by about 1.2 million a year in both periods, 23.9 million from 1996 to 2016 and 12.1 million since. Cats number 77.0 million, up from 58.3 million in 2016. But average annual household pet spending is $1,478 in 2026 against $1,727 in 2025, down 14%, and CATalyst Council found puppy visits down 10% in July to September: a larger pet population has not meant more spending or, for puppies, more visits. AVMA News: Dogs reign, cats closing the gap

THE BACKGROUND SIGNAL

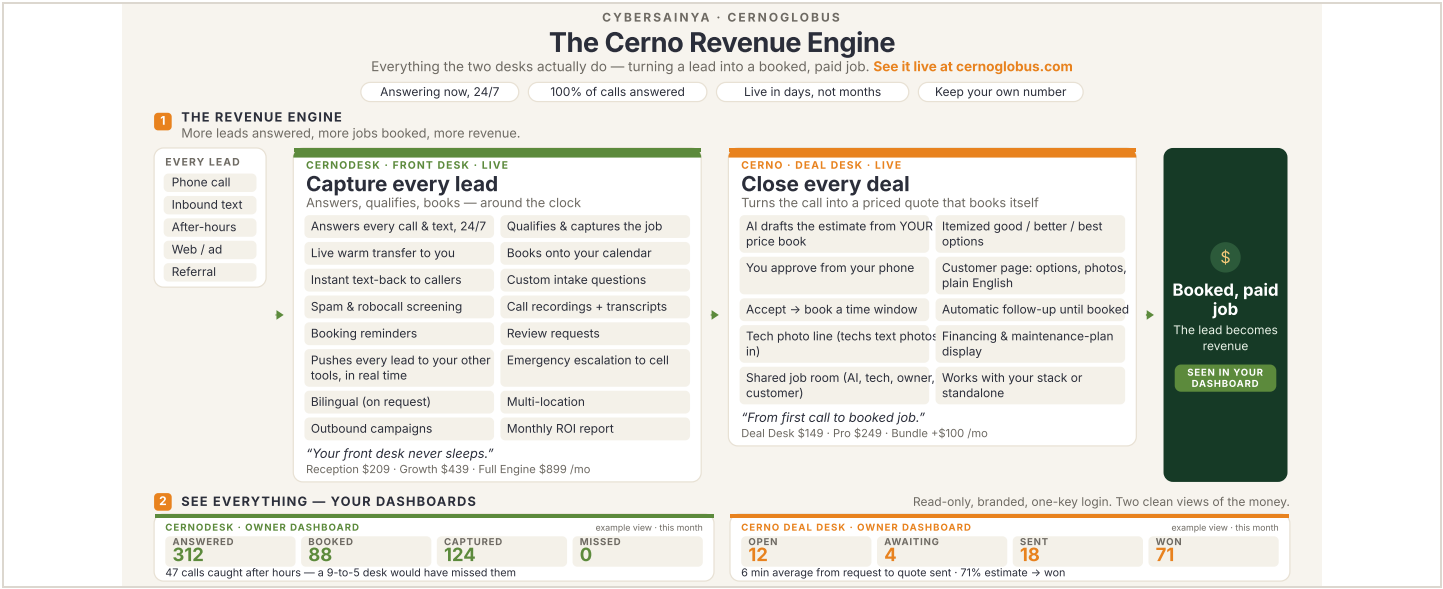
The fraud that reads your invoices before it sends one

The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center took 24,768 business email compromise reports in 2025, with losses of $3.05 billion — a record, after dipping to $2.77 billion in 2024 from $2.95 billion in 2023. Across all internet crime it logged 1,008,597 complaints and $20.88 billion in losses. Reported cases only, so read it as a floor.

Business email compromise, not ransomware, is the one that should concern an independent practice. Someone gets into a mailbox, reads until they understand how you invoice and who pays you, then sends a real-looking progress billing with different bank details. No malware, no warning — just a payment that never arrives and an argument about who eats it. A practice that emails claims, statements and supplier invoices all day is the shape this is built for. The quieter number is adoption: under 20% of firms with fewer than 20 staff use AI at all.

What to do about it: You don't need a security program. You need multi-factor authentication on email and your accounting login, and one rule everybody follows: nobody changes bank details on the strength of an email or a call — you ring the number you already had on file and confirm. That covers most of it, and costs nothing. The part it doesn't — how the systems are set up — is the day job of our parent company, CyberSainya.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center, 2025 Internet Crime Report — reported cases only, rounded from $2,946,830,270, $2,770,151,146 and $3,046,598,558. U.S. Census Bureau, Business Trends and Outlook Survey, May 3, 2026.



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